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The Origins of Judaism

Key Terms

Monotheism — The belief in only one God.

Covenant — A mutual promise or agreement between God and the people.

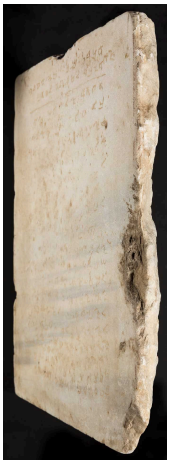
Torah — The first five books of the Hebrew Bible, considered the most sacred writings.

The history of the Hebrew people began in a region called Canaan. Located at the eastern end of the Mediterranean Sea, Canaan was a "cultural crossroads." It connected the great empires of Egypt to the west and Mesopotamia to the east. According to the Torah, God chose a shepherd named Abraham to be the father of the Hebrew people. Around 1800 B.C., God commanded Abraham to move his family from the city of Ur in Mesopotamia to Canaan.



Canaan was a crossroads between major ancient empires.

Unlike their neighbors who worshiped many different gods (polytheism), the Hebrews were monotheists. They believed in one God, whom they called Yahweh. The Hebrews believed in a **covenant**, or a special promise: if they obeyed God, God would protect them. This belief system, known as **ethical monotheism**, emphasized right conduct and worshiping only one God. This idea was unique in the ancient world and became the foundation for Judaism.



Life in Canaan was not easy. The geography was harsh, featuring arid deserts, rocky wilderness, and hot valleys. Because of a drought and the threat of famine, many Hebrews migrated to Egypt. While they were welcomed at first, they were later forced into slavery by the Egyptian pharaoh.

The Ten Commandments provided a moral code for the Hebrew people.

Between 1300 and 1200 B.C., a leader named Moses led the Hebrews out of Egypt in an event called the **Exodus**. During their journey across the Sinai Peninsula, Moses climbed Mount Sinai. The Bible says he spoke with God and brought down two stone tablets carved with the **Ten Commandments**. These laws became the basis for Jewish civil and religious life. The Hebrews wandered in the desert for 40 years before returning to Canaan, where they transitioned from nomadic tribes to settled farmers and city dwellers.

As the Hebrews settled back in Canaan, they organized into twelve tribes. In times of trouble, judges would provide leadership. Eventually, the tribes united under three powerful kings to form the kingdom of **Israel**.



King Solomon built a great temple to glorify God and house the Ark of the ...

Saul was the first king, chosen for his success in fighting the Philistines. He was followed by **David**, a popular leader who established Jerusalem as the capital and founded a dynasty. David's son, **Solomon**, became the most powerful king. He built a magnificent temple in Jerusalem to house the Ark of the Covenant. However, Solomon's building projects required high taxes and forced labor. This caused great discontent. After Solomon died, the kingdom split in two: Israel in the north and Judah in the south. From the name Judah, the Hebrew people became known as Jews, and their religion became Judaism.

Check Your Understanding

1. How did the religious beliefs of the Hebrews differ from most of their neighbors in the ancient world?

Circle the correct answer.

A) They practiced monotheism, the belief in only one God.
B) They did not believe in any gods or spiritual beings.
C) They believed their kings were physical gods on Earth.
D) They worshiped many local gods associated with specific places.

2. Describe the geography of Canaan. How did this environment affect the history of the Hebrew people?

3. Which king was responsible for establishing Jerusalem as the capital city of the united kingdom of Israel?

Circle the correct answer.

A) Solomon
B) Abraham
C) David
D) Saul

4. Explain the concept of the 'covenant' between Abraham and God. What did each side promise?

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Environment and Belief Systems

This activity helps you analyze how the world around the ancient Hebrews shaped their unique way of life. Use the reading passage "The Origins of Judaism" to complete the following questions. These will prepare you for your whiteboard Mind Map task.

Part 1: The Physical Environment

1. Canaan is described as a "cultural crossroads." Based on the text and map, why was its location so important to the empires of Egypt and Mesopotamia?

2. The geography of Canaan and the Sinai Peninsula was harsh. List three specific physical features mentioned in the text and explain how the drought affected the Hebrew people.

Part 2: Core Beliefs and Adaptation

3. The Hebrews practiced **ethical monotheism**. How did having a single set of moral laws, like the Ten Commandments, help the twelve tribes stay unified even when they lived in separate territories?

4. According to the concept of the **covenant**, what was the primary reason the Hebrews believed they could survive in a harsh environment?

Circle the correct answer.

A) They moved back to the city of Ur where resources were more plentiful.
B) They believed the desert environment was naturally easy to farm.
C) They relied on the advanced irrigation technology of the Philistines.
D) They believed God would protect them in exchange for their obedience.

Part 3: Mind Map Sketch

5. Before you move to the whiteboard, draft a Mind Map below. In the center, write **"Hebrew Survival."** Create three branches connecting to it: **Environment**, **Beliefs**, and **Leadership**. In each branch, add at least two details from the text that show how they are connected.

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Key Terms and Figures

Directions: Use the information from the reading passage to complete the vocabulary table and the identification chart for major leaders. Be sure to focus on their specific contributions to the Hebrew system of belief or government.

Key Term	Definition and Significance
Torah	
Monotheism	
Covenant	
Exodus	
Ethical Monotheism	

Major Leaders of Israel

Leader	Major Contribution to Belief or Government
Abraham	
Moses	
Saul	
David	
Solomon	